RECOVERY AT HOME

Recovery after angioplasty and a stent

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

What happens after angioplasty?

Angioplasty opens a narrowed heart artery. A stent may help keep the treated area open. Medicines, follow-up, and healthy habits remain important after the procedure. Recovery depends partly on whether treatment was planned or followed a heart attack. Follow your own discharge plan. [1,4]

Protect your medicine routine

Medicines that reduce clot formation are often prescribed after a stent. Stopping them early can increase the risk of the treated artery becoming blocked. Ask which medicines you need, how long to take them, and what to do if a dose is missed. Never stop a prescribed antiplatelet medicine without speaking to the clinician responsible for your care. Plan refills before the supply runs out. [1,3]

Ask before another procedure

Tell doctors, dentists, and pharmacists that you have had a stent and show them your medicine list. If surgery or dental treatment is planned, ask the treating teams to coordinate any medicine decisions. Do not stop treatment because you expect bleeding or because someone gives general advice that ignores your stent history. If instructions conflict, ask for clarification before acting.

Care for the access site

The catheter may have entered through a blood vessel in the wrist or groin. Follow the hospital’s advice about the site, bathing, and activity. Ask what bruising or discomfort may be expected and what change is concerning. Learn what to do if bleeding occurs or the limb becomes painful, cold, or numb. Serious bleeding or another sudden severe problem needs urgent medical attention. [2]

Confirm activity and work advice

Ask when you may walk, lift, exercise, drive, and return to your job. Your condition and the reason for the procedure affect the answer. A person recovering from a heart attack may need a different plan from someone having planned treatment. Ask about rehabilitation and how it fits the next stage. Do not use the absence of pain as the only test of readiness. [1]

Keep the review appointment

Bring your questions and updated medicine list to follow-up. Report symptoms, concerns about the access site, and problems obtaining medicines. Ask whether any tests are needed and how to reach the team between visits. If you are unsure which clinician manages a particular issue, ask directly. A clear point of contact can prevent a problem from being passed around without a plan.

Keep emergency action clear

A stent does not make new chest symptoms harmless. New chest pressure, severe breathlessness, fainting, or suspected heart attack symptoms need urgent assessment. Follow your emergency instructions rather than waiting for a routine review or email reply.

References

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4. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Angioplasty and stent placement — heart. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/article/007473.htm

Cardiac Rehabilitation Unit
Cardiac Center · Bicol Medical Center
3rd Floor, 5-Storey Building · BMC Road, Concepcion Pequeña
Naga City, Camarines Sur 4400
0917-155-7163 · bmccardiaccenter@gmail.com
Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
https://jusanmisolas.github.io/bmccare/